

ABCs of Politics

Syllabus for the Conférence de méthode

Assessment Structure:

The assessment structure for this seminar will be threefold:

- Attendance and participation (20%)
- In-person group presentation (40%)
- A 2500-word Mid-term essay (40%)

The essay questions have already been posted on Moodle and more instructions will follow as to what will be expected of you for the essay and presentation.

Week 1: What is political Theory?

This week we ask: what is political theory? What is it that we do in political theory? What questions do we ask? and what do we hope to achieve as political theorists? To prepare for this seminar please read Leo Strauss, *What is Political Philosophy?* To support you in your reading ask yourself: is political theory anchored towards theorizing 'the good' - that is, theorizing models of governance that will be conducive to the good? Or is political theory about describing what politics actually is - what its role is, what its scope is, etc.?

Essential Reading:

- Leo Strauss, *What is Political Philosophy?*

Week 2: Liberalism and Rawls' Theory of Justice

This week we turn to Rawls' *Theory of Justice* which remains the magnum opus of liberal political theory. In this text, Rawls seeks to generate a conception of justice that *anyone* (i.e. any "free and rational person") would accept under specific conditions of equality. These specific conditions of equality are specified by what Rawls calls 'the original position' and 'the veil of ignorance'. It is under these precise conditions that Rawls articulates a theory of justice as fairness. This week we will elaborate what Rawls takes to be the necessary conditions for justice as fairness.

Essential Reading:

- Chapter 1: Justice as Fairness, *A Theory of Justice* - John Rawls

- Chapter 3: The Original Position, *A Theory of Justice* - John Rawls

Week 3: Libertarianism and Nozick

Last week, we explored John's Rawls framework of justice as fairness. This week, we explore the work Robert Nozick who advances a libertarian critique of Rawls' distributive paradigm. In particular, he advances an alternative model for thinking about justice which he labels the 'entitlement' theory of justice. Through his account, Nozick emphasizes the primacy of individual liberty as a sphere to protect at all costs thus advancing a potential tension between the idea justice and liberty. Are his concerns legitimate? Is his alternative better than Rawls'?

Essential Reading:

- Chapter 7: Distributive Justice in *Anarchy, State and Utopia* - Robert Nozick

Week 4: Republican Freedom and Pettit

This week we turn to the idea of republicanism. In particular, we will focus on republican ideas of freedom. In contrast to liberalism and libertarianism which qualifies freedom as an individual sphere of action, republicans see freedom as non-domination. Philip Pettit advances what remains one of the most important iterations of negative freedom – that is freedom as non-domination. On his understanding, freedom is the sphere in which no external power can exercise its will. From this distinct negative understanding of freedom, Pettit elaborates a theory of republican governance.

Essential Reading:

- Chapter 2: Liberty as non-domination in Philip Pettit's *Republicanism: A Theory of Freedom and Government*

Week 5: Marxism

This week, we turn to Marx's critique of capitalism. We do with a special emphasis on Marx's diagnosis of alienated labour and exploitation. What exactly does Marx lament about the failings of capitalism? What are the political implications of his critique, especially in relation to ideas about justice, liberty, and equality? Most importantly, we will reflect on whether Marx offers a concrete political alternative by reading Marx and Engels' eponymous *Communist Manifesto*.

Essential Reading:

- *The Communist Manifesto*, Marx and Engels

Week 6: Power

This week we turn to the concept of power - what exactly does it encompass? Who holds it and how is it used? Most importantly, how is it perpetuated and how can we resist it? For Foucault, power runs deep - indeed, it is not enough to understand power through the prism of sovereign authority, but we must also look at how power is internalized by subjects in the way that we speak, think, and conceive of ourselves in the world. Indeed, for Foucault, power is integrated by subjects such that it comes to constitute subjects themselves. To guide your reading, ask yourself the following questions: where does power operate? How does it interact with the subject?

Essential Reading:

- Michel Foucault, "The Subject and Power"

Week 7: Capital

This week we turn to the notion of capital and reflect on the entire economic and political structure that this notion has produced. In particular, we focus on Marx's account of 'the fetishism of commodities' where he elaborates a political economy of the commodification of labor under capitalism. How does the commodification of labor and the fetishism of commodities fit within his wider alienation critique of capitalism?

Essential Reading:

- Marx's essay 'Estranged Labor'
- Read Chapter 1, Section 1 of *Capital* "The Two Factors of a Commodity" Section 4 "The Fetishism of Commodities"

Week 8: Patriarchy

This week we turn to one of the most important works in the history of feminist political thought - namely, Carole Pateman's *Sexual Contract*. In this text, Pateman advances a critique of social contract theory on the grounds that it legitimized a political fiction of a freely consented contract that enabled the subjection of women. She subsequently appeals to her critique of contractarianism to advance a critique of the marriage contract.

Essential Reading:

- Chapter 6: Feminism and the Marriage Contract in Carole Pateman's *Sexual Contract*

Week 9: Racism

While last week we explored Pateman's account of how social contract theory created patriarchal subjection, this week we turn to Charles Mills' critique of the social contract on the grounds that it established white supremacy – that is, the racial domination of whites over racialized peoples. On this account, the social contract is only a contract that was enacted between white folk which in turn allowed for the systematic exploitation of racialized folk. This week we turn to the specific moment in the Racial Contract in which Mills advances the particular argument that contractarianism led to a distinctly racialized form of exploitation.

Essential Reading:

- “The Racial Contract is an Exploitation Contract” in Charles Mills' Racial Contract

Week 10: Environment

This week, we turn to questions regarding the environment and how these have been dealt with in political theory. In particular, we will be interested in the ‘the politics of adaptation’ which pertains to the problem of how to integrate environmental concerns in a political habitus in which the environment has consistently been cast aside as politically irrelevant. To approach this question, we will discuss the idea of ‘green capitalism’ and the extent to which such a politics of adaptation merely replicates patterns of exploitation that are likely to fail environmental concerns.

Essential Reading:

- “A Green Capitalism?” in Wainwright and Mann's *Climate leviathan: a political theory of our planetary future*.

Week 11: Democracy

For our final week for this course, we approach the hefty theme of democracy. This contested concept becomes especially rife on questions of representation. What form must representation take in order to attend to democratic principles of equality?

Essential Reading:

- Chapter 5 “Political Representation” in Hanna Pitkin's *The Concept of Representation*
- Chapter 1 “From a Politics of Ideas to a Politics of Presence” in Anne Phillips, *The Politics of Presence*